



HAUTE

layered,

then stripped ;



Layered, then Stripped

WHERE THE LAYERS FALL

I strip down to bare skin. A tremble lies in my hand; his gaze holds me, cements me to the floor and forces me to reconcile with what is mine. What is me. I've always worn an ego, figuring the grasping claws of others couldn't puncture through it. 'You're a star! You're a star!' they shout as their faces distort and melt into the facade around them, unnatural and inhumane. It's not a message that I want to hear, nor one that rings true. It's an insult thrown in my face, a reminder of the false ego I sport as a means of hiding the scars beneath. Like waves, ever ebbing and flowing, crashing ceaselessly onto the shore, I have gained and lost a consciousness of who I believe I am. I once wore scars as a sign of strength, proof that I have lived and will live again, that I have struggled and relinquished to the fates.

As I stand here in front of him, asking for acceptance, perhaps I am better off unguarded, willing to scab and scar under the hands of others. I have always easily scarred anyway. As an untethered die floating meaninglessly in a magic eight ball, he holds a reminder to my truth - the scorecards held up are blank, there is no eternal eye of judgement. With or without him, I am me purely – without the layers, without the defense. I wear it loudly now: an everpresiding protest against fallacy, although maybe an overshoot of the truth. I believe I've learned to shatter the mirror, to bring myself to the table with no extraneous sides, but has the overshoot snowballed into yet another defense? Am I a biased version of the truth?

He strips me down once more with the incessant passion of a greyhound whipping through the wind, incited by a need. I yearn to enter the circle of dance of which I watch, where passions fly free and embarrassment is fleeting. They act as themselves and enjoy it immensely, and I stand on the sidelines.

I pace back and forth, as though looping around and around the endless spirals of hell, a Virgil without reason. His hands guide me back. I stare at my bare self, resisting the nomadic noise of the eight ball, the calls from a state of doubt. It is I and me; I used to believe I was two stark sides of a coin, equidistant in nature but contrary in belief, a being of two. Past and present, though both a lie. Now, I stand here and be. Stripped down in his eyes, yet whole. You may not see me tomorrow - the defense often neglects lying siege, but believe that one day, I will be freed from the layers, finding comfort in the bareness of myself. I do not regret the forfeit to truth. Rather, I honor and grace it. I grapple with it and let it consume me. His hands have freed me, a Michelangelo molding my mind, releasing the strain on a pre-existing art of existence. For once, I praise him for baring me to the world, body and soul. I step into the dance circle, limbs moving free from restraint, layers drooping from my bones as ragged cloth, itching to finally fall free to the floor.

TRICIA MERONE





LAYERED

In this shoot, Rina and I explore the idea of the masking and covering layer. We incorporate theatrical elements, such as animal masks and exaggerated poses, in our depiction of domestic life.

By performing and hiding our inner lives to conform to the roles assigned to us, we end up trapping ourselves and others in a never-ending performance. The photoshoot focuses on conventions surrounding gender roles, particularly in the household. Through grotesque, eerie, and absurd elements, the shoot sheds light on how unsettling these masks can become, when they start to mold onto our faces.

Another aspect we wanted to highlight was ridicule. The lengths we go to in order to conform reaches a level of absurdity, obvious to every gaze except our own.

When I first saw the photos, I could not help but giggle at the seriousness of its subjects, juxtaposed with the absurdity of their performance. The mask traps us in a spectacle that is tragic and ridiculous all at once.

words & direction --
MARIA DE FEO

II





STRIPPED

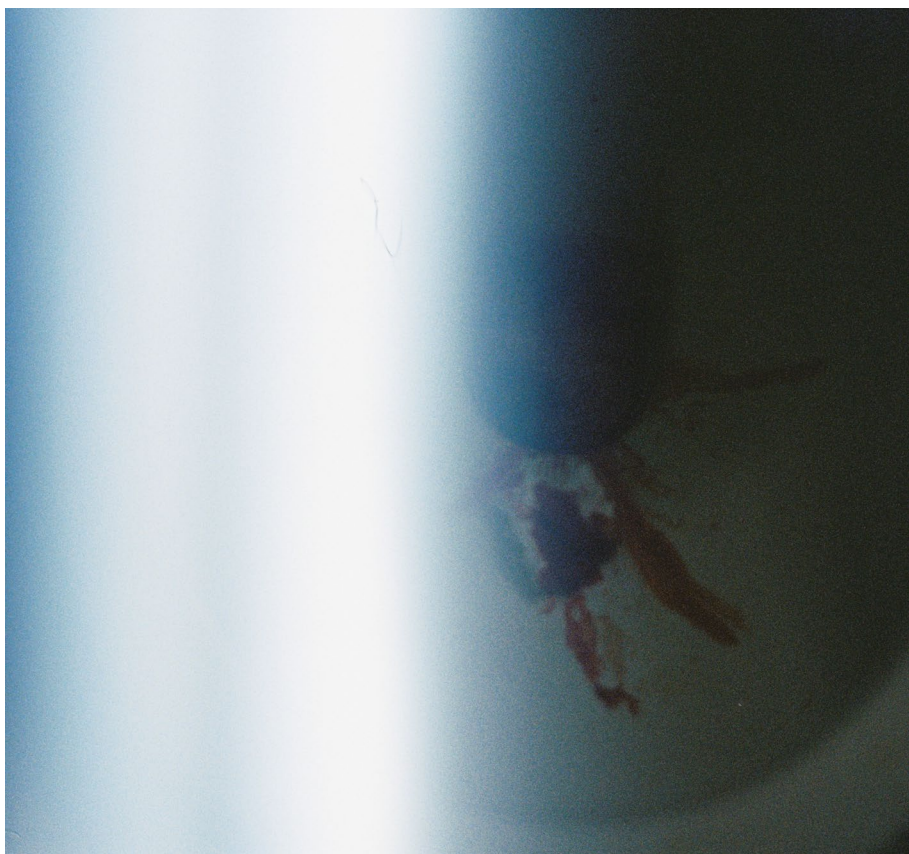
III



Stripped: It is not an uncommon theme in the St Andrews fashion scene. A large part of the student fashion shows involves striking bodies, lingerie, and defiant stares. However, this image is, to me, as much of a layer as Barbour jackets and Ralph Lauren polo jumpers, or some society merch. Stripping, when stoic, aroused, moody, or conventional reveals only more mystery. This section explores what we are when we truly strip ourselves of our layers. We are surrounded by a variety of 'authentic', 'open expressions.' These somehow make us more layered than ever- take online therapy culture as an example. For every new expression we learn, we design a self-checklist. So, in this shoot, we show what happens when we unbundle all our edges, and at the core, we are just plain ol' us. Rather than being stripped physically or emotionally bare, let's imagine being stripped back to being seen as lovable. The moles, pimples, veins, and smiles that, to our loved ones, are so very us. Playful, kind, and a little rose-tinted. Under all the layers that protect us and tell us who we are, are we fundamentally lovable, as many theists claim? I couldn't think of a better model to work with than Charlie Macbeth, one of my first friends at this university. Authentic, open, and a little theatrical. Through him we get to explore "stripped" as tender and unbound rather than a final defiant layer.

words & direction --
ARIELLE FRIELANDER

















Chapter V
LAYERED, THEN STRIPPED

